

Who Commits, Who Talks? Treaty Rhetoric vs Commitment

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Background

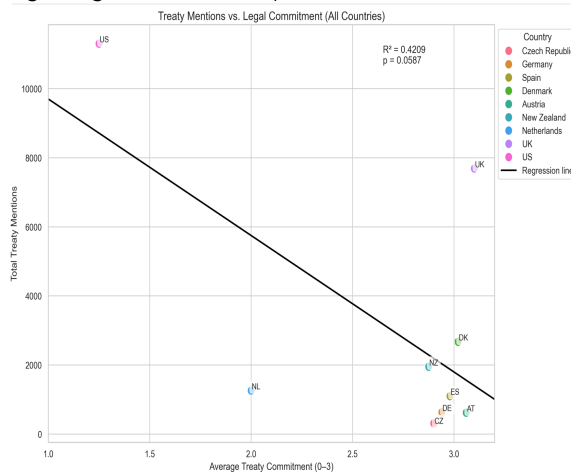
International treaties are often viewed as tools to promote cooperation and accountability. However, their impact varies. Some agreements lead to institutional change, while others are ignored or used as symbolic gestures. Scholars continue to debate whether signing and ratifying a treaty reflects genuine intent to comply or serves primarily as a diplomatic signal.

This study explores how commitment to treaties is expressed not only through legal actions but also through references in national political discourse. This approach highlights an underexamined indicator of state engagement and offers new insight into how international agreements function in practice.

Research Questions

Does stronger commitment to international treaties lead to greater rhetorical engagement in government discourse?

This study examines whether legal commitment reflects genuine alignment or serves as symbolic signaling in international politics.



The US skews the relationship between treaty rhetoric and legal commitment. A moderate negative correlation is observed.

Methods and Materials

Treaty commitment was analyzed across 10 democracies from 1990–2017, comparing treaty mentions in official speeches to legal commitment levels for 8 major international treaties.

Speeches were sourced from ParlSpeech V2 (1990–2023) and the HeinOnline Daily Congressional Record (43rd–114th Congresses), compiled by Stanford. Commitment was coded on a 0–3 scale. Python was used for data extraction and analysis. A key limitation is that the analysis focused only on legislative speeches, excluding executive orders, press releases, and other forms of government communication.

Results

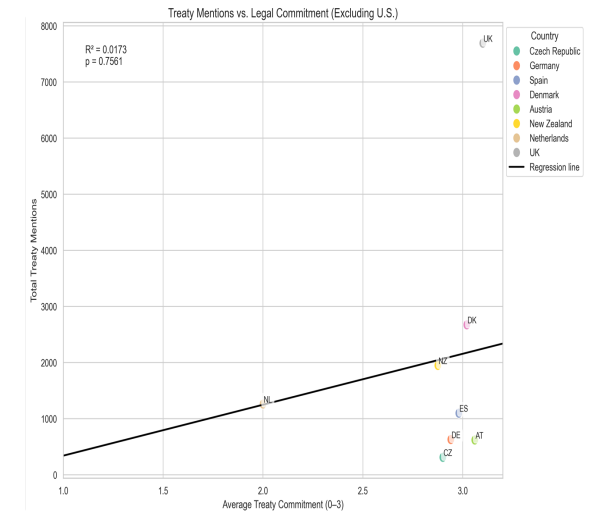
Higher legal commitment to treaties does not consistently correspond with more frequent mentions in official discourse. A modest negative correlation appears when all countries are included ($R^2 = 0.42$, $p = 0.059$), a trend largely driven by the United States.

The U.S. shows unusually high rhetorical engagement despite low commitment. When excluded, the correlation disappears ($R^2 = 0.02$, $p = 0.756$), suggesting rhetorical engagement may function symbolically. Legal commitment does not always translate into robust legislative discourse.

Conclusion or Discussion

These findings challenge the idea that legal commitment to treaties is matched by rhetorical engagement. The U.S. case raises questions about the use of treaty discourse as a symbolic rather than legal tool in democratic governance.

Future research could expand beyond legislative speeches to include executive communications, social media, and policy documents. Examining other treaty types and non-democratic states may clarify how rhetorical strategies vary across systems.



With the United States excluded, the correlation disappears. This divergence suggests that the U.S. engages in symbolic discourse unanchored to legal commitment, a pattern more often associated with non-democratic regimes.

Acknowledgments

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References

ParlSpeech V2 Dataset. (1990–2023)

HeinOnline Daily Congressional Record. (43rd–114th Congresses). Compiled by Stanford Libraries.